

The Last Run of the Polar Star

An interactive detective story by Alfa



Alfa Creativity · CODE Eternal

Chapter 1



Outside the windows of the Polar Star express, the January blizzard of 1958 was raging. Lev Orlov calmly sipped strong tea from a nickel-silver glass holder. He was fifty-two, and after long, tense years in the criminal investigation department he was finally counting on a perfectly quiet journey. The soft light of the table lamp fell on his pale face, his short, combed grey hair and his thick grey moustache. A brown wool suit and an immaculate white shirt made him look more like a professor on holiday than a seasoned detective. On the velvet seat opposite, the huge ginger cat Watson slept peacefully, now and then twitching a fluffy ear to the steady rhythm of the wheels.

The cosy calm was broken by a sharp, frantic knock at the door. The conductor appeared on the threshold, white as a sheet. He was breathing heavily, nervously crumpling his uniform cap in his hands.

“Comrade Inspector!” he gasped. “Trouble! Madame Sokolova’s Northern Lights is gone! The diamond itself!”

Orlov unhurriedly put his glass down on the table. Watson opened one green eye and yawned in displeasure, his whole look saying that the theft of the century could have waited until morning.

“Gone?” Orlov asked again, his brown eyes studying the trembling railwayman closely. “But the train runs without stops.”

“That’s just it! Her compartment is locked from the inside with a steel bolt — she opened it to me herself just now. The window is a sealed winter one. Nobody came in or out, the whole carriage swears the corridor was empty! And the jewellery box is open and empty!”

The inspector sighed heavily, straightened his moustache and slowly rose from his seat. His holiday was officially over. He scooped up the disgruntled Watson under his arm and stepped confidently into the cool corridor of the carriage.

Chapter 2



Madame Sokolova's compartment smelled of heart drops and heady French perfume. The victim, wrapped tightly in a down shawl, sat on the edge of her bed, nervously fanning herself with a fan made of theatre programmes. On the table by the window, an open jewellery box lined with blue velvet gaped forlornly empty.

The moment Orlov crossed the threshold, Watson shot out of his arms like a bullet. In a single leap the cat flew onto the back of the sofa, stretched out like a string and stared up at the very ceiling. The fur on his scruff stood on end, and a menacing, continuous hiss came from his throat.

The inspector followed his fluffy assistant's gaze. The target of the feline fury turned out to be the narrow ventilation grille above the door.

"Calm down, citizen Sokolova," the detective said in an even, confident voice. "We'll get to the bottom of it."

He pulled up a stool, carefully stood on it and took a closer look at the vent. Unlike the wooden panels, covered with a barely visible layer of travel dust, the edges of this grille were suspiciously clean. What is more, one of the small screws holding the metal frame was missing, and the second was screwed in only halfway.

Orlov cautiously prised the grille. It gave way easily with a quiet creak, revealing a dark duct leading deep into the carriage. A cold draught drifted from the narrow rectangle. Watson hissed even more furiously, trying to strike an invisible enemy in the darkness with a clawed paw.

"So the door was locked," the inspector murmured thoughtfully, taking a handkerchief from his pocket. He carefully removed a thin dark thread caught on the sharp edge of the metal. "But who said the thief needed to come in through the door at all?"

The detective jumped down from the stool and turned to the pale conductor frozen in the corridor.

"Where does this duct lead?"

Chapter 3



The conductor swallowed hard, wiping the sweat from his brow.

“To the next one, compartment nine, Comrade Inspector. That... foreigner is travelling there. A businessman from Europe, Monsieur Lange. A very secretive type. Hasn’t shown his nose the whole way — I just leave his tea outside the door.”

Orlov nodded knowingly and, putting away the thread he had found, stepped into the corridor. With a guttural growl, Watson jumped down from Madame Sokolova’s sofa, shot to the door of compartment nine and sat right under the brass handle.

The detective knocked firmly. The answer was a ringing silence, broken only by the howl of the January blizzard behind the double glass.

“Open up!” he said commandingly.

The lock clicked reluctantly. The door opened a crack, and a narrow, displeased face in horn-rimmed glasses peered out. The foreigner was wrapped in a dark chunky-knit wool sweater — a perfect match for the evidence just taken from the vent.

“What is it?” Lange drawled with a heavy accent. “I was asleep.”

The detective did not waste time on small talk and stepped confidently inside, forcing the passenger to back away. The compartment was in exemplary order, but one detail caught the eye at once. On the table lay a folding metal probe — a long telescopic tube with a thin mechanical clamp at the end.

Watson immediately jumped onto the table, sniffed the cold metal and sneezed contemptuously.

“An interesting gadget for a man who was peacefully asleep,” the detective smirked, shifting his gaze to the vent below the ceiling. Its grille turned out to be half unscrewed. “Explain yourself, monsieur.”

Chapter 4



Monsieur Lange turned pale, looking at the telescopic probe, but did not manage to say a word in his own defence. Orlov's attention was suddenly drawn by a piercing miaow from the corridor.

The inspector turned sharply. The conductor, who had been shuffling at the threshold of compartment nine all this time, suddenly recoiled in fright. Watson, gracefully arching his back, was rubbing insistently against his uniform trousers — but not at all out of sudden affection. The cat rose gracefully on his hind legs, slipped a clawed paw into the deep side pocket of the railway jacket in a flash and, with a triumphant purr, fished out something shiny.

The object rolled with a soft ring along the carpet runner of the corridor. In the dim light of the carriage sconces icy sparks flashed — it was the Northern Lights. The large diamond shimmered with every facet, as if mocking those gathered.

A heavy pause hung in the air. Lange adjusted his glasses in surprise, and the conductor flushed red in blotches, gasping for air.

"It... it's not mine!" he squealed, pressing himself against the wooden wall panel. "I didn't take it! I swear, Comrade Inspector! I had no idea that bit of glass was in my pocket! Someone planted it on me!"

Orlov calmly picked up the jewel and measured both suspects with a heavy, penetrating gaze. A foreigner with an ingenious burglar's tool and a conductor with a hidden stone. Too many absurd coincidences for one night run through a blizzard.

Meanwhile Watson, having completely lost interest in the frozen conductor, went back into the compartment in a businesslike manner, jumped onto Lange's berth and began eagerly digging with his paws into the neatly packed travel bag, clearly having scented something even more intriguing there.

Chapter 5



There was the sound of a lining tearing. Working furiously with his hind paws, Watson flung out of the foreigner's bag a silk tie, a pair of starched collars and a tiny black pouch. It landed on the table, the drawstrings came loose, and under the light of the dim carriage lamp out rolled... another diamond.

The stone sparkled exactly like the one Orlov had just picked up from the floor. The same perfect facets, the same cold brilliance. Two Northern Lights in one carriage in the middle of the snowy taiga.

Lange turned so pale that he seemed about to blend into the walls of the compartment. He clutched his chest and sank heavily onto the lower berth.

"An astonishing multiplication of jewels in captivity," the inspector chuckled, carefully taking the second stone and holding it up to the light together with the first. "I suppose, monsieur, you will now have to explain not only the telescopic probe but also why you were carrying an exact copy of the stolen diamond."

The foreigner swallowed nervously, casting hunted glances now at the detective, now at the ginger cat, who was now calmly washing himself, sitting on the torn luggage.

"I... I was only supposed to swap it!" Lange forced out hoarsely. "I was paid generously in Moscow. They said Madame Sokolova wouldn't even notice the difference! I got the probe in through the ventilation, hooked the stone out of her box, but as I was pulling it back... it slipped. Fell somewhere into the dark of the duct!"

Orlov turned his heavy gaze on the conductor trembling in the corridor.

"So it slipped into the duct," the detective drawled thoughtfully. "And ended up in the pocket of a uniform jacket. What an astonishing trajectory."

Suddenly the train jerked sharply, the wheels beat out an alarming drumroll, the brakes screeched, and the light in the carriage went out completely, plunging everyone present into absolute, ringing darkness.

Chapter 6



In the pitch dark the clanging of the brakes was deafening. The carriage shook violently. Orlov instinctively clenched his fist, but too late: someone's cold, clinging fingers brushed roughly across his hand. An invisible hand snatched both stones straight out of his fist with frightening force.

"Stop!" the detective barked, lunging forward at the sound of a stranger's breathing, but he ran only into the soft upholstery of a berth.

There was a stifled squeak from the conductor, a dull thud and the sound of a body falling. At the same moment a furious feline yowl came out of the darkness. Watson, with his perfect night vision, threw himself across the robber's path. There was the crack of tearing fabric, desperate hissing and the heavy thud of feet running away towards the vestibule.

Orlov instantly pulled a petrol lighter from his pocket. The wheel struck, throwing a shower of sparks, and a tiny tongue of flame snatched the chaos of compartment nine out of the gloom.

The conductor sat on the floor, holding his bruised cheekbone. Lange was pressed into the corner, trembling finely. And in the doorway, his tail menacingly fluffed and his ears flattened, stood Watson. In his teeth the fighting cat firmly held a torn scrap of dark-blue velvet — a fabric that neither the foreigner nor the railwayman had any clothes made of.

"So we have a third player," the inspector stated grimly, snapping the lighter shut as the emergency lighting began to blink dimly in the corridor. "And he is in a great hurry to leave this train."

The detective stepped over the threshold, casting a fleeting glance at the broken glass of the door at the end of the corridor. The blizzard howled through the breach, sweeping snow onto the carpet runner. Watson spat out the velvet evidence, tore off and raced along the trail.

Chapter 7



Orlov rushed down the corridor, barely keeping up with the ginger lightning bolt that was Watson. The cold air from the broken window burned his face, but the detective did not slow down. Throwing open the heavy door of the vestibule, he stopped short. The howl of the blizzard was deafening here, and snow swirled in the dim light of the one surviving bulb, coating the metal floor with an icy crust.

By the half-open outer door, clinging convulsively to the iced-over handrail, stood Madame Sokolova. Her luxurious dark-blue velvet dressing gown billowed in the piercing wind. The lower edge of its hem was raggedly torn — a perfect match for the scrap that Watson had brought back so triumphantly in his teeth.

“Madame Sokolova?” the detective called sharply over the noise of the storm. “Isn’t it rather a cold night for a stroll?”

The lady started and turned sharply. Her usually haughty face was now distorted by genuine horror mixed with despair.

“Comrade Inspector!” she breathed out, letting go of the rail. “I... I heard a scream! I came out of my compartment, and here in the dark someone ran into me and nearly pushed me off the train! I barely held on!”

Watson came right up to her, suspiciously sniffed the hem of the velvet gown and growled deep in his throat.

“Nearly pushed you off, you say?” Orlov took a step forward, closely watching her hands, clenched convulsively inside her deep pockets. “And it seems to me that you were in a great hurry to leave the carriage yourself. And took something extra with you. Both Northern Lights at once, isn’t that so?”

Sokolova lifted her chin haughtily, but her voice trembled treacherously.

“You are raving! My stone was stolen! Why would I rob myself?”

A sudden gust of wind flung the vestibule door wide open. The train jerked sharply again, picking up speed. At that moment a heavy metal object slipped out of Madame Sokolova’s pocket and struck the iron floor with a loud clang. It was not a diamond at all.

Chapter 8



With a desperate cry the woman threw herself onto the icy floor, trying to grab the bunch of keys, but the inspector's boot came down gently yet firmly on the metal ring.

"Careful, madame, you'll catch cold," Orlov said in an icy tone.

He bent down, picked up the jingling bunch and held it up to the dim bulb. Massive shanks, distinctive square bits, a brass tag stamped with a number. Watson came closer and snorted in disgust at the cold metal.

"What an interesting find," the detective drawled thoughtfully. "A bunch of official carriage keys. As far as I know, ordinary passengers are not issued these. Whereas our frightened conductor mentioned not long ago that he had mysteriously lost his spare set."

Sokolova slowly straightened up. Her lips were trembling; her aristocratic arrogance had finally given way to primal fear.

"You don't understand anything..." she whispered, pressing herself against the frost-covered wall of the vestibule. The blizzard tossed her hair, generously powdering it with snow. "It was only insurance! I had to make sure the cargo in the baggage car..."

"So this isn't about the Northern Lights at all?" Orlov narrowed his eyes, raising his voice over the roar of the train hurtling through the storm. "You staged the theft of the diamond yourself to divert our attention! A brilliant performance. While we were crawling around the compartments, you were planning to open the end door with these keys. What exactly are you hiding in there?"

At that moment Watson gave a warning hiss and turned his muzzle towards the corridor. From the dark depths of the train came a muffled but distinct metallic grating. Someone had just turned a key in the lock of that very baggage door.

Chapter 9



The door of the baggage car creaked ajar, letting an icy draught into the vestibule. Out of the thick shadow, stumbling and glancing around like a hunted animal, tumbled Monsieur Lange. Not a trace remained of his former respectability: his hair was dishevelled, his coat thrown on all askew, and his teeth were chattering hard — whether from the piercing cold or from animal fear.

In his trembling palms, glimmering dully in the light of the one surviving bulb, lay both Northern Lights.

“I... I found them,” the foreigner forced out in a breaking voice, barely able to stand. “They were hidden in a sack of coal... There, behind the door!”

Watson arched his back menacingly and hissed, clearly not believing a single word. Orlov frowned, shifting his stern gaze from the ashen Sokolova to the trembling Lange.

“Miracles of intuition, Monsieur Lange,” the detective snorted sarcastically, taking a slow step towards him. “So in complete darkness, scared to death, you decided not to hide in your compartment but to go looking for the stones in the baggage car? And quite by chance you found them in the coal?”

“It’s the truth! I swear!” Lange squealed, pressing the diamonds to his chest. “I saw someone slip in there after the lights went out! I followed...”

“Lies!” Madame Sokolova suddenly shrieked, tearing herself away from the frosted wall. Her eyes glittered wildly. “He’s in league with the conductor! They wanted to take my cargo, and the stones are just a cover!”

The train lurched sharply on a steep bend. Lange lost his balance and flung out his arms. One of the sparkling diamonds slipped from his fingers, struck the iron floor of the vestibule with a ring and rolled swiftly straight towards the wide-open outer door, beyond which the night blizzard raged.

Chapter 10



A ginger lightning bolt shot across to cut it off. A screech of claws on metal — and with a graceful leap Watson pinned the sparkling stone firmly to the icy floor with his furry paw, just a millimetre from the gaping abyss.

Orlov nodded with satisfaction, stepped forward and slammed the outer door shut, cutting off the howling of the blizzard. The silence that fell in the vestibule seemed deafening.

“Brilliant work, partner,” the detective said, picked up the icy crystal, calmly dropped it into his pocket and turned to the frozen passengers. “So, the picture is clear. On this train the interests of two completely independent swindlers collided by chance. You, Monsieur Lange, in league with the conductor, were smuggling contraband diamonds hidden in sacks of coal. And you, Madame Sokolova, staged a theft of a fake so that, in all the commotion, you could slip into the baggage car and save your own, far bulkier illegal cargo.”

Lange glanced, hunted, at the ginger cat, who had now quite unambiguously unsheathed his claws, and limply opened his fingers. The second Northern Lights fell with a thud at the detective’s feet. Sokolova slumped heavily against the wall and closed her eyes. Her grand plan had collapsed completely.

A few hours later the blizzard died down. The first rays of the pale winter sun slid across the frosted windows as the express drew smoothly to a halt at the platform of a large station, where a militia squad summoned by telegraph was already waiting for the criminal trio.

Orlov sat in the warm compartment, unhurriedly sipping strong tea from a cupronickel glass holder. On the little table in front of him lay a neat stack of completed reports. And on the velvet seat beside him, Watson, with noble dignity, was finishing a double portion of choice doktorskaya sausage. The case of the Polar Star was closed.